UX RESEARCH · CASE STUDY

Building a usability measurement system from zero

Establishing SUS benchmarking as a repeatable practice across a multi-product SMB platform



62 studies · 25 feature areas · 7 product areas · Thryv, 2023 to 2026 · Jang Soo Lim

The question we could not answer

“How usable is our product, actually?”

Seven product areas, dozens of features, several of them inherited through acquisition, and no shared way to say how any of it performed.

Investment ran on anecdote

- The case for redesigning a feature was whichever support tickets and sales complaints were loudest that quarter.
- No way to compare one feature against another, so no defensible way to rank where UX effort should go.

We could not prove a redesign worked

- Teams shipped improvements and had nothing to point at except that the new thing looked better than the old thing.
- Research produced findings, but no evidence of its own value.

The constraint that shaped everything

7

major product areas the research team was accountable for

25

distinct feature areas inside them, plus acquired products

1

small research team, far outnumbered by the surface area

The real design problem was never “how do we measure usability.”

It was how to measure it in a way one small team could sustain across dozens of features, repeatedly, for years.

Why I chose SUS

1

It produces a number that means something outside our own walls

Decades of published norms, an established grade curve and adjective ratings. I was not asking stakeholders to trust an index I had invented.

2

It rides along with work we were already doing

Ten items at the end of a session, a couple of minutes, moderated or unmoderated. One session, two payloads: a benchmark and everything a usability test normally gives you.

3

It is cheap enough to repeat

Short and standardized, so re-running it on a redesigned version is close to free. That repeatability is what turns a score into a before-and-after.

What SUS cannot do, and how I covered it

The limitation

SUS is a global perception measure. It tells you a feature feels hard. It does not tell you which part of it is hard.

On its own it would have handed leadership a scoreboard and handed product teams nothing they could act on.

Studies ran five to eight participants, a floor rather than a quota. If patterns had not formed by the eighth session, I kept recruiting. Small samples make any single score directional, not precise, and I said so every time.

What I paired it with

- A completion rubric scored for every task: unaided, completed with assistance, or failed.
- A single-ease rating after each task.
- A confidence rating after each task.
- Session observation, noting where people went quiet and started hunting.

The score told you that a feature was underperforming and by how much. The task data told you where. The observation told you why. A score never left my hands without a diagnosis attached.

What stayed fixed, and what did not

Free to vary: moderated or unmoderated · thirty minutes or sixty · as many tasks as the feature needed · whoever reads that area best

Fixed in every study: the layer that makes scores comparable

1

Completion

The same three-point rubric, scored on every task

2

Ease

A single-ease rating captured in the moment

3

Confidence

Rated per task, on the same scale throughout

4

SUS

Ten items, administered identically every time

5

Friendliness

One closing overall rating

I standardized the measurement, not the session. Fixing session length or task count would have been false rigor, because a six-task linear flow does not need the same container as a sprawling configuration surface. Recruiting flexed the same way, though the usual default was people who fit our ideal customer profile but had never used the product: testing with existing customers measures how well they have adapted to it, testing with newcomers measures the thing itself.

A taxonomy so the scores could roll up

Comparability only pays off if scores aggregate. Some features genuinely belong to two parts of the product, and naive tagging either double-counts them or forces an arbitrary choice.

LEVEL 1

Product area

Seven areas covering the full platform

LEVEL 2

Feature area

Twenty-five features nested beneath them

OPTIONAL

Secondary pair

A second area and feature, for genuinely cross-cutting work

The rule I enforced: a study counts exactly once, however many tags it carries, so rollups stay accurate while cross-cutting features still surface in both places.

From spreadsheet to dashboard

Version 1: Excel tracker

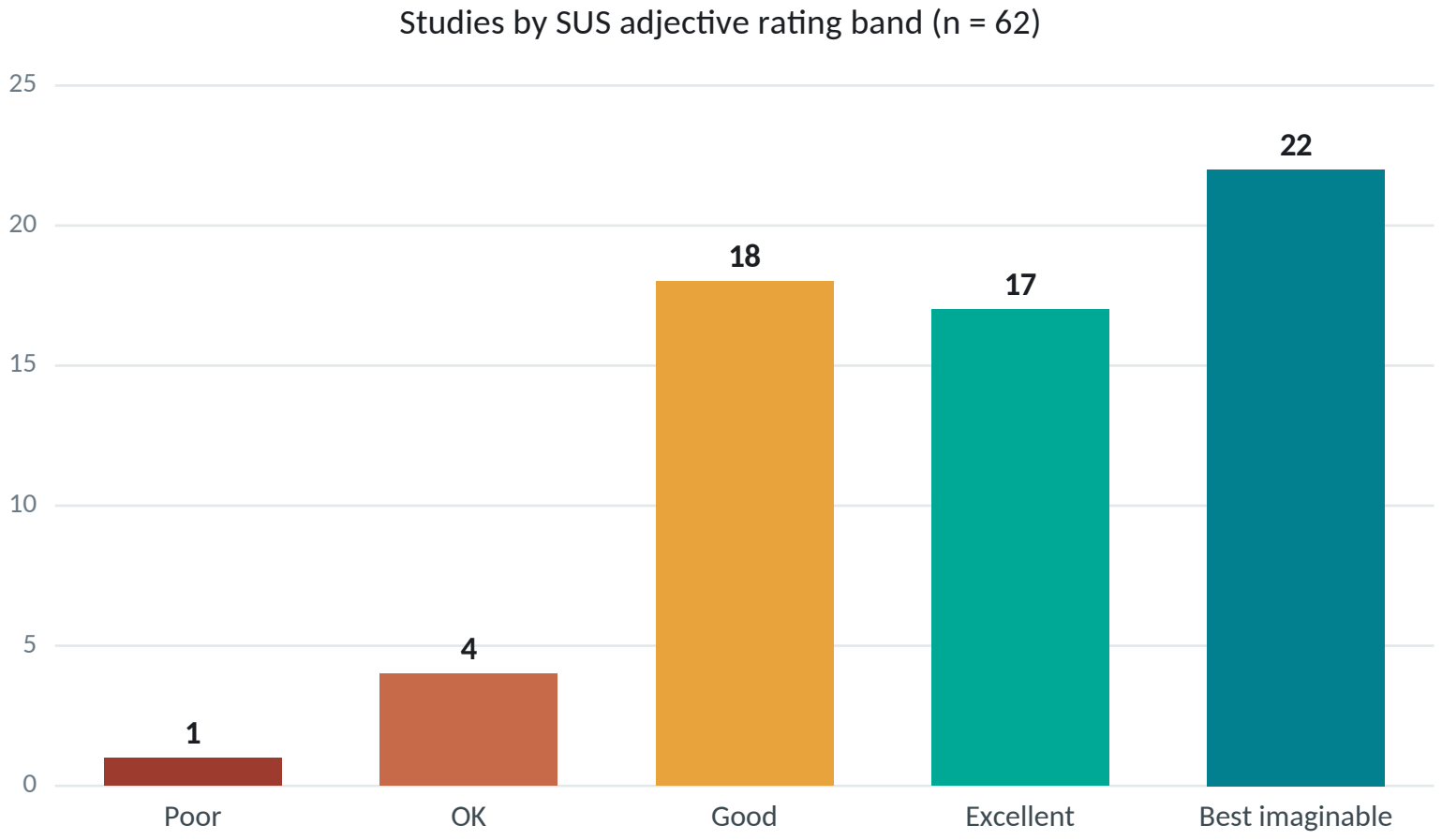
- Fastest thing that could possibly work, and the right place to start.
- One row per study, tagged against the taxonomy.
- Did the job for the research team and almost nothing for anyone else, because a spreadsheet is a file someone has to remember to open.

Version 2: HTML rollup report

- The whole platform on one page, filterable by product area, feature, rating band and study type.
- Scores rendered against the adjective scale, with a target line.
- Each baseline paired to its later benchmark, showing the delta, so improvement was visible as movement rather than two loose numbers.

The format change was the adoption change. Product managers and designers do not open a research spreadsheet. They do open a page they can filter to their own area and see their own number.

The first finding was not the average



Platform average: mid-70s

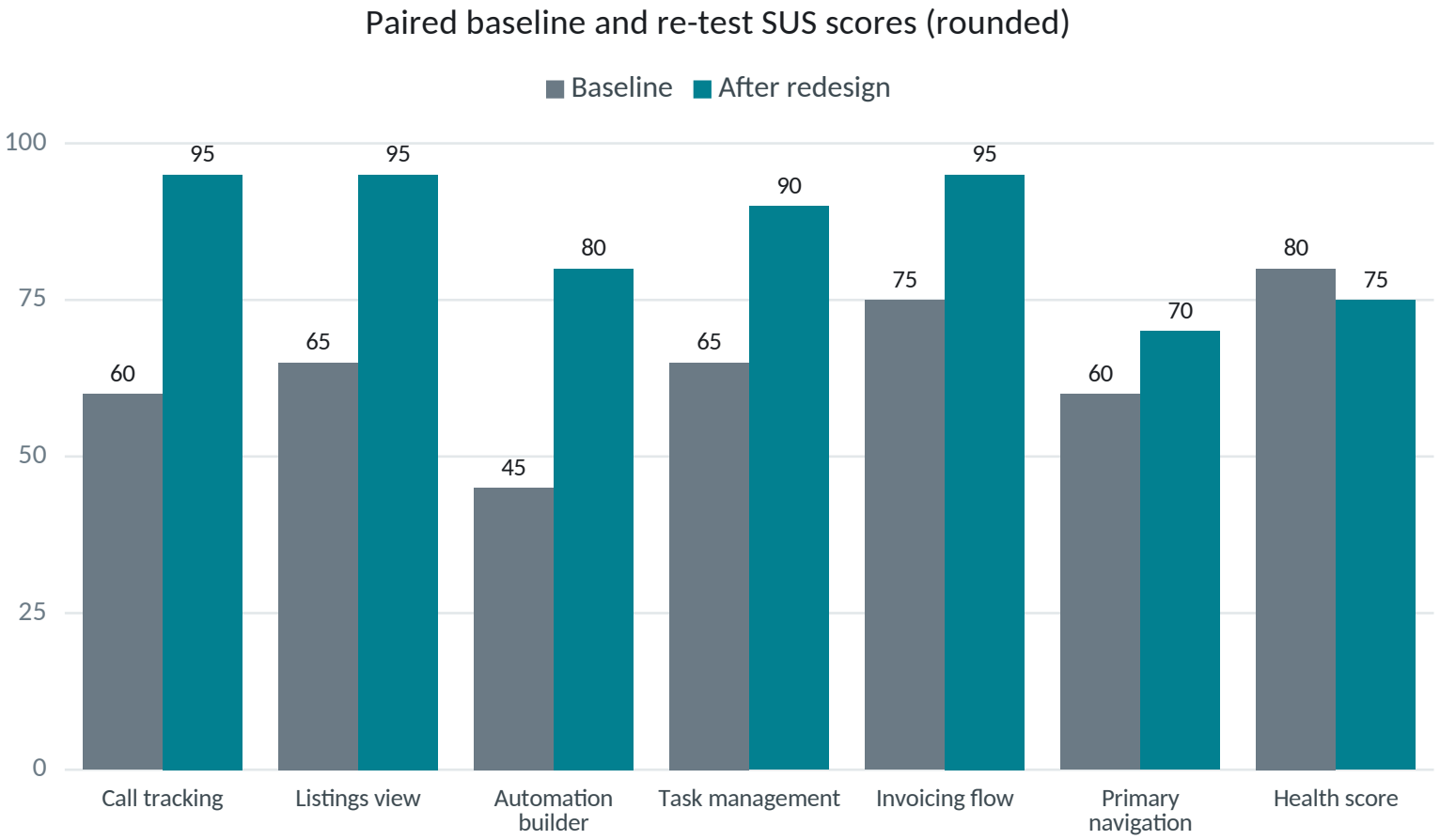
Around the Good/Excellent boundary. A reassuring number, and the least interesting one on this slide.

Range: low 20s to high 90s

That spread was the first real finding of the program. We did not have a usability problem. We had a usability ***consistency*** problem, with a handful of features dragging the experience far below what the rest of the platform delivered.

Nobody had seen it, because nobody could see the features side by side.

Re-tests proved the redesigns worked



9 of 10

paired re-tests showed improvement, several by thirty points or more, enough movement to cross two full rating bands.

One came back lower

I reported it as prominently as the wins. A measurement system that only catches good news is not a measurement system. It is marketing.

Scores rounded; exact figures held as internal data.

ONE STUDY, UP CLOSE

Researching a feature we were about to delete

Unified inbox baseline · moderated · ICP-fit participants who had never used the product

The score was the least useful thing about it

High 60s

SUS score, the Good band, but well below the platform average

The unusual thing about this study was its purpose. The feature was already slated for deprecation, so no amount of insight was going to improve it.

Ten core workflows, tested with first-time users drawn from our ideal customer profile. Task-level data pointed straight at the weak spots: composing a new message and creating a label were by a clear margin the hardest tasks, both in completion rate and in participants' own confidence ratings.

So I reframed the question.

Not “how do we fix this,” but “what must we not carry forward.”

What we found, and what it prevented

Filter read as search

Participants repeatedly reached for search when they wanted to filter the inbox, producing errors, because the two affordances read as interchangeable.

Bulk actions were hidden

The control was unintuitive enough that most people needed several attempts to find it. Several asked for selection checkboxes to simply be visible by default.

Pin a message vs. pin a thread

The distinction was invisible to users, who frequently did one when asked to do the other.

Channel selection confusion

Choosing which channel to send from was confused with the channel filter, the same control pattern meaning two different things.

Labels were hard to locate

A core organizing feature, and most participants hunted before finding where to create one.

None of this improved the inbox. All of it became a constraint list for the product that replaced it, and for every other team building messaging features.

The study's entire value was in what it stopped us from rebuilding.

What changed

1

A baseline, where there had been none

Every major feature area carries a score, a band and a date. Three years of history to compare against.

2

Evidence that redesigns worked

Paired re-tests turned “we think this is better” into a measured delta the team could point at.

3

A shared vocabulary and a target

Product and design teams argued about usability using the same scale, against a number we had agreed to aim for.

4

A defensible investment queue

The lowest-scoring features stopped being a matter of opinion and became the obvious candidates for UX effort.

What I would do differently

1

Build the taxonomy first

I designed the category structure after about a dozen studies were already done, then had to retrofit tags and reconcile inconsistent naming. The structure was right; the sequencing cost me real time.

2

Write down the format rule

I chose moderated or unmoderated, short or long, on judgment about the feature. The calls were mostly right, but the reasoning lived in my head, so it was not reproducible and never tested for a format effect on scores.

3

Show uncertainty on the page

Early on I presented single scores with more precision than small samples deserved. I would put confidence ranges in the dashboard itself rather than relying on me being in the room to caveat them.

4

Instrument the dashboard

I know the HTML report was used more than the spreadsheet because people told me so. I never measured it, and for a tool built to drive adoption that should have been data too.

The through-line: I was rigorous about measuring the product and not rigorous enough about measuring my own system.

Thank you

Happy to go deeper on the protocol, the taxonomy design, the dashboard, or any individual study.



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